The gerund after verbs of preference

Goal: To use the gerund (verb + -ing) correctly after verbs of preference such as *like, love, enjoy, prefer, hate, can't stand* and *don't mind*, in order to talk about your tastes, hobbies and the job you would prefer.

The idea in two lines: A gerund is the -ing form of a verb used like a noun: *reading, swimming*. After verbs that express what we like or dislike, the second verb takes the gerund: *I enjoy reading*, not *I enjoy read*.

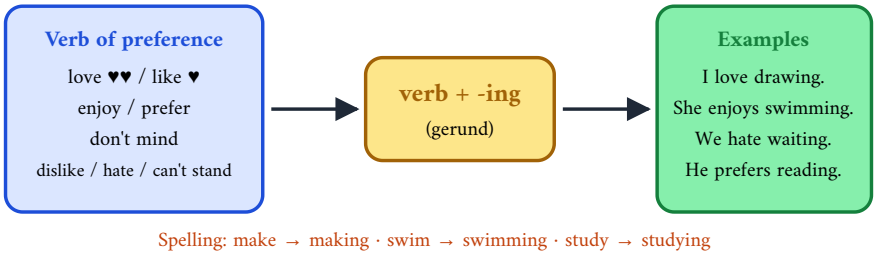


Figure 1: After a verb of preference, the next verb takes the -ing form.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Gerund = verb + -ing** used as a noun. It can be a subject (*Swimming is good for health*) or an object (*I like swimming*).
2. **Verbs of preference + gerund:** like, love, enjoy, adore, prefer, dislike, hate, can't stand, don't mind, be fond of, be keen on, be interested in.
3. **Spelling rules:** final silent *-e* disappears (*write → writing*); one vowel + one consonant → double the consonant (*run → running, sit → sitting*); *-ie → -ying* (*lie → lying*); *-y* stays (*play → playing*).
4. **Comparing preferences:** *prefer + gerund + to + gerund*: *I prefer walking to driving.* Also *I'd rather + base verb*: *I'd rather walk.*
5. **Negative form:** put *not* before the gerund or use the negative of the main verb: *I don't like getting up early.*

6. **Questions about tastes:** *Do you like playing chess? What do you enjoy doing at weekends?*
7. After a preposition, the verb is also a gerund: *She is good at singing. He is interested in coding.*

🟢 Examples

1. Complete: *Salim can't stand ..... (wait) in queues, but he doesn't mind ..... (help) his mother at home.* **Solution:** can't stand **waiting** ... doesn't mind **helping**. **Explanation:** both are verbs of preference, so both take -ing.
2. Write a sentence with *prefer ... to*: *Meriem / read novels / watch TV.* **Solution:** Meriem prefers **reading** novels **to watching** TV.
3. Correct the spelling: *I love swiming and danceing.* **Solution:** I love **swimming** and **dancing**. **Explanation:** double the *m* in *swim*; drop the *e* in *dance*.

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Base verb after the preference verb: *I enjoy play football* ✕ → *playing* ✓.
- *prefer ... than* ✕ → *prefer reading to watching* ✓.
- Spelling: *writeing, runing, studing* ✕ → *writing, running, studying* ✓.
- Forgetting the *-s* on the main verb with he/she: *She enjoy singing* ✕ → *She enjoys singing* ✓.

🟡 Quick review

- like / love / enjoy / hate / can't stand / don't mind + verb-ing.
- prefer + -ing + to + -ing; would rather + base verb.
- Drop silent -e, double the final consonant, -ie → -ying.
- Gerund after prepositions: good at, interested in, fond of.
- Gerund can be a subject: *Reading is fun.*